Chapter 4

Distinct Norm Communities and Shaming Issue Choice

4.1 Introduction

Why do some human rights issues receive greater attention at the United Nations than others? Recent work has argued that states favor certain issues when shaming adversaries and others when shaming allies (Terman and Byun, 2022). Notably, this account rests on the theory that both states' issue preferences and targets' issue sensitivities follow a uniform pattern across the international system.

This assumption of uniformity stands in tension with scholarship that views international norms as contested, evolving, and subject to selective appropriation (Dixon, 2017; Dukalskis, 2023; Meyerrose and Nooruddin, 2025). If states actively shape human rights norms and prioritize different topics (Glendon, 1997, 1156, Jensen, 2016), then their issue preferences in shaming should also diverge in systematic ways.

In answering the question of when states emphasize what issues in their shaming, this paper advances three arguments. First, I revisit the core claim that states systematically shame adversaries more than allies and assess whether that relationship holds across all issue areas.

Second, I evaluate whether the assumption of uniform issue preferences is tenable. Specifically, I ask whether, net of affinity with the target, states display heterogeneous shaming profiles across issue areas. Third, I propose an exploratory hypothesis that such heterogeneous issue emphases cluster into communities. To uncover this hidden variation, I introduce a methodological approach that applies community detection to standardized residuals from issue-specific network models, mapping clusters of states with distinct normative alignments.

Three findings follow. Consistent with conventional wisdom, states are more likely to shame adversaries than allies across all issue domains (Hypothesis 1). Yet contrary to the uniformity assumption, states' issue preferences vary significantly across issue areas (Hypothesis 2). Moreover, this variation is structured: community detection reveals clusters of states whose shaming practices reflect shared normative commitments that cannot be reduced to geopolitical affinity (Hypothesis 3). These clusters highlight the role of mid- and small-sized states in maintaining the cohesion of normative communities, underscoring their influence in shaping global human rights discourse.

Taken together, these findings reframe the politics of international shaming. Rather than treating human rights as a domain governed only by strategic alignment, the analysis shows that normative heterogeneity is central to how states engage with international review processes. Norms are not only contested but also clustered, sustained by coalitions that cut across material alliances. Methodologically, the paper demonstrates how network-based approaches can reveal hidden normative structures that traditional regression models miss.

Future research should trace how these communities evolve over time, how dissenting states challenge prevailing agendas, and how institutional designs like the UPR mediate the balance between affinity and normative diversity. More broadly, the findings call for an account of international human rights politics that looks beyond power politics to the interplay of affinity, heterogeneous norms, and the structure of the normative communities, in which even the smallest states can have an outsized impact.

4.2 Hypotheses

Scholars consistently show that shaming is a political exercise. Across multiple arenas, including the UN Human Rights Council's Universal Periodic Review (UPR), regional intergovernmental organizations, and voting in the UNHRC, states are far less likely to criticize allies or politically aligned partners (Lebovic and Voeten, 2006; Donno, 2010; Hug and Lukács, 2014; Terman and Voeten, 2018; Park and Park, 2025). Building on this established role of geopolitical affinity, I expect such political selectivity to apply in all issue domains of human rights. In other words, states should be systematically more reluctant to shame allies across all areas of human rights — civil and political rights, economic rights, and migrant rights, while being more willing to target adversaries in these domains.

Hypothesis 1 (Replication)**.** States are more likely to shame adversaries than allies in all issue domains of human rights.

However, recent work offers a different perspective on the determinants of shaming. To address the tension between political selectivity and the widely shared desire of states to present themselves as impartial defenders of human rights, Terman and Byun (2022) advances a compelling theory: states tend to direct regime-threatening criticisms at adversaries while limiting their criticism of allies to domains perceived as less sensitive. According to this account, shaming is most consequential when it challenges the target regime's legitimacy, particularly by highlighting highly stigmatized violations of physical integrity rights (Terman and Byun, 2022, 4). It is also sensitive when it involves compliance with costly norms, such as civil and political rights related to free expression and political participation. Migrant rights, in the context of rising anti-immigrant sentiment, have similarly become a politically and financially burdensome issue (Terman and Byun, 2022, 5). By contrast, they suggest that socioeconomic rights, women's rights, and children's rights are generally safer domains for criticism, as they are less directly threatening to regime stability (Terman and Byun, 2022, 5). Other areas they classify as less regime-threatening include rights related to

governance and the justice system (Terman and Byun, 2022, Figure 1). Their theory does not classify Racial, Ethnic, and Religious Minorities and LGBT rights into either category (Terman and Byun, 2022, 11).

Importantly, this theory rests on two key notions. First, it implies that states and targets broadly share a similar profile of issue sensitivities: for example, both Saudi Arabia and Japan would be expected to regard shaming over women's rights as relatively less threatening than shaming over political participation. Second, it suggests that states share a relatively uniform set of issue preferences as senders: holding constant their relationship with a potential target, they are assumed to be similarly willing to enforce norms around protecting LGBT populations and ensuring economic rights.

While these assumptions help the theory establish a coherent baseline, the framework leaves open important questions about whether such uniformity of issue sensitivity and preference can be taken for granted across diverse international contexts. Human rights may represent a "new standard of civilization" (Donnelly, 1988), but this standard is itself shaped through the practices of states as members of the international system. Like any norms, human rights are dynamic social products, actively made and contested (Finnemore and Sikkink, 1998; Jensen, 2016). States use speech, voting behavior, and coalition-building at the United Nations to influence which rights are prioritized (Dixon, 2017; Dukalskis, 2023; Meyerrose and Nooruddin, 2025).[1] States promote new standards or resist existing ones across diverse domains, from freedom of religion (Baderin, 2003) and torture (McKeown, 2009) to online freedoms (Hulvey, 2023) and socioeconomic rights (Alston, 1993; Arat, 1999; Sceats and Breslin, 2012; Berger, 2023). Consistent with this view, descriptive evidence from the UPR shows that states on average focus on different issues, though without fully theorizing how these issue preferences interact with geopolitical alignment (Terman and Búzás, 2021).

This paper therefore offers a corrective to the existing claim that states share homo-

[1] At the public opinion level, shaming in a given issue area increases support for the international norm (Bassan-Nygate, Accepted).

geneous preferences over which issues to emphasize for adversaries and allies. Instead, I argue that states exhibit heterogeneous preferences in the issues they prioritize to shame, net political affinity. Explaining the sources of this heterogeneity lies beyond the scope of this paper, but prior case studies and issue-specific research suggest that political context, regime type, and evolving norms all shape states' priorities and positions in international discourse (Alston, 1993; Baderin, 2003; McKeown, 2009; Donno et al., 2022; Berger, 2023).

Hypothesis 2 (Corrective)**.** Controlling for affinity, states exhibit heterogeneous preferences over which issue areas they emphasize in shaming.

If issue preferences are heterogeneous, how is that variation structured? Prior work shows that international institutions are not merely arenas for material bargaining but also sites where states align into communities of practice, reinforcing particular human rights commitments (Terman and Búzás, 2021). Building on this insight, I expect that states will cluster into meaningful communities with distinct normative profiles that cut across geopolitical affinity.

Hypothesis 3 (Exploratory)**.** Issue preferences cluster into communities not reducible to material alignments.

4.3 Data

To evaluate the hypotheses, I use data from the Universal Periodic Review (UPR), compiled by UPR Info and widely employed in research on international human rights politics (Terman and Voeten, 2018; Terman and Búzás, 2021; Terman and Byun, 2022; Kim, 2023; Meyerrose and Nooruddin, 2025). The UPR is a peer-review process in which every UN member state's human rights record is evaluated by all other members on a rotating four and a half year cycle. Prior to each review, the state under examination and relevant stakeholders including regional organizations and civil society groups submit reports that are compiled by the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR). During the review session,

member states issue recommendations identifying areas for improvement. A state may issue none, one, or several recommendations, and the government under review must formally respond by either supporting or "noting" (rejecting) each recommendation. Following the session, a report summarizing the dialogue and recommendations is published, and states may optionally submit a mid-term update before their next review.

The dataset covers the first two full review cycles (2008–2016). It includes 54 issue labels hand-coded by UPR Info experts, which are grouped into seven thematic clusters by Terman and Byun (2022): Civil-Political Rights, Governance and Public Service, Migration, Physical Integrity Rights, Race and Religious Discrimination, Socio-Economic Rights, and Women, Children, LGBTQ, and Disabled.[2] Following Terman and Byun (2022), I exclude sender–target dyads in which no recommendations were made in either cycle, in order to focus only on cases where shaming could occur.

4.4 Findings

4.4.1 Hypothesis 1

Replication To assess whether states are more likely to shame adversaries than allies across different human rights issue domains, I closely follow the approach developed in the existing study, with one modification in model specification. Using the same data, I include all observations regardless of the issue label of the shaming recommendation and estimate a single ordinary least squares (OLS) regression model. This model adds fixed effects for issue while retaining all other control variables from the replicated study, including geopolitical affinity between reviewer and target (Voeten et al., 2009), the shamer's and target's physical integrity rights protections (Fariss et al., 2020), shared region, and fixed effects for sender, target, and year. Estimating one OLS model, rather than seven separate models for each thematic cluster, allows the analysis to account for systematic differences across issue

[2]Appendix F.1, Table F.1 lists the specific issue labels included within each thematic cluster.

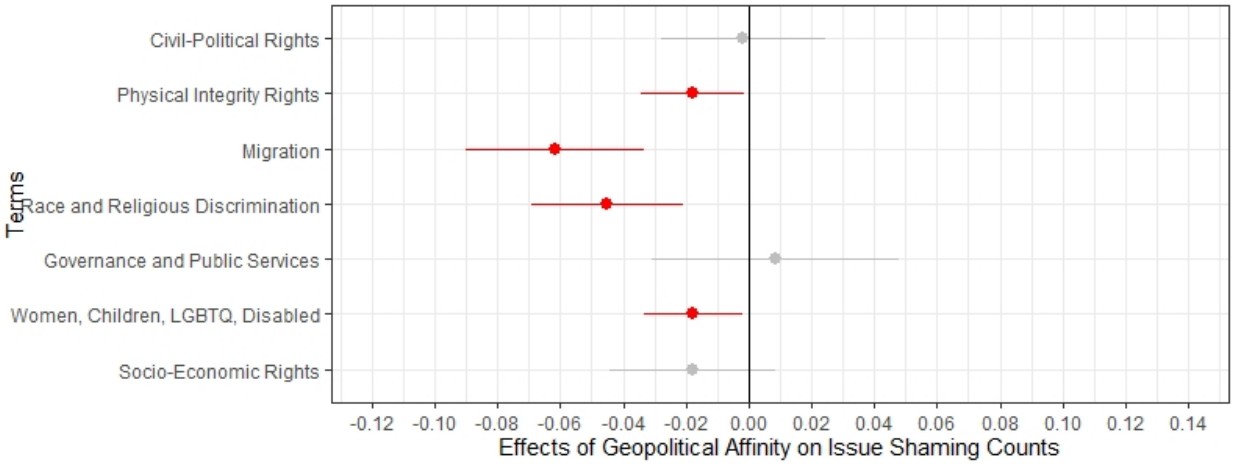


Figure 4.1: Effects of Geopolitical Affinity on Issue Shaming Counts

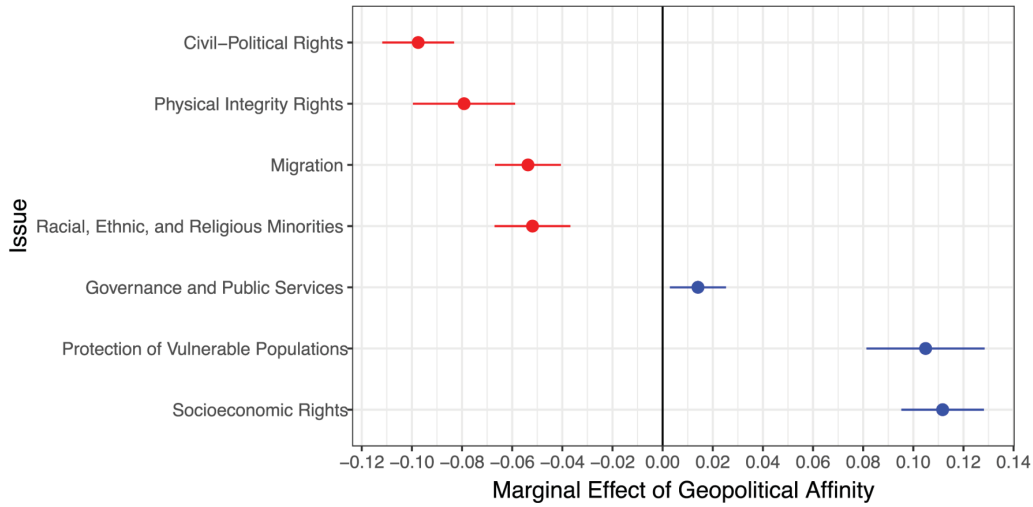
Note: The estimates of the β coefficients show that the marginal effect of geopolitical affinity on the number of recommendations offered by a given reviewer for each issue category, controlling for the same factors as the original study, is mostly negative and statistically significant. Some issue areas, such as Governance and Public Service have non-negative estimates, but the standard error is very large.

domains while producing directly comparable coefficient estimates.

Figure 4.1 reports the estimates of the β coefficients, which capture the marginal effects of political affinity on shaming. Hypothesis 1 predicts that the interaction term between political affinity and each issue should yield negative coefficients. Consistent with this expectation, four issue areas (Physical Integrity Rights, Migration, Race and Religious Discrimination, and Women, Children, LGBTQ, and Disabled) display negative and statistically significant relationships with political affinity. In three domains (Civil-Political Rights, Governance and Public Services, and Socio-Economic Rights), the results is not statistically different than zero, suggesting that senders do not systematically differentiate between adversaries and allies when shaming on these issues. Full regression results are provided in Appendix F, Table F.2.

Some of these results stand in direct contrast to the previous study, which found that allies are more frequently shamed on issues concerning vulnerable populations such as women, children, LGBTQ individuals, and people with disabilities. In this analysis, the opposite pattern emerges, with a highly significant effect ($\hat{\beta} = -0.018, p = 0.029$). Moreover, contrary to

FIGURE 3. Effect of Geopolitical Affinity on Recommendation Counts, by Theme



Note: The *x*-axis denotes the marginal effect of Geopolitical Affinity on the number of recommendations offered by a given reviewer for each thematic category, controlling for other factors. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals. Issues are ordered top to bottom by corresponding point estimates on the *x*-axis. Colors indicate sign and significance of the effect of Geopolitical Affinity on number of recommendations.

Figure 4.2: Main Figure from the Previous Study

Note: Reported figure from the original paper, based on seven OLS models estimated separately for each of the seven thematic issue clusters. I present this figure rather than the alternative one based on 54 OLS models (one per issue label), as the latter is too large to display and the seven-model specification provides a more direct comparison with my corrected estimates in Figure 4.1.

the expectation that states would shame adversaries more often over civil and political rights violations, the findings indicate no significant difference in shaming between adversaries and allies for such violations ($\hat{\beta} = -0.001, p = 0.895$). Similarly, the results diverge from the theory that allies are more frequently targeted than adversaries on governance- and justice-related issues or socio-economic rights ($\hat{\beta} = 0.008, p = 0.675$ and $\hat{\beta} = -0.018, p = 0.189$, respectively). In sum, the general pattern of negative or null relationships between geopolitical affinity and shaming is consistent with prior evidence that states tend to be more lenient toward those with whom they share closer political ties (Lebovic and Voeten, 2006; Donno, 2010; Hug and Lukács, 2014; Terman and Voeten, 2018).

The difference between the two studies, despite their reliance on the same data and OLS regression strategy, arises from differences in model specification. Figure 4.2, taken from the

replicated study, reports estimates and their margins of error (represented by red, grey, and blue circles and bars) to show whether states differentiate between adversaries and allies in their shaming behavior when the data are subset by issue category. However, because these estimates are generated from 54 separate OLS models, they are not directly comparable across issues.

Introducing Sender's Issue Preference The replication with modification provides estimates that are comparable across issues. However, the inherent limitations of having sender and target fixed effects in the model limits our ability to account for an important assumption: that senders prioritize different human rights norms, and these priorities shape their shaming behavior. Again, numerous studies indicate that states interpret human rights differently and actively work to shape international human rights norms in line with their values (Finnemore and Sikkink, 1998; Jensen, 2016; Cordell et al., 2020; Hulvey, 2022; Dukalskis, 2023). In the context of the Universal Periodic Review, where states either endorse or undermine norms by choosing to shame or remain silent, descriptive evidence shows that countries are *fragmented* across issues, holding divergent normative positions (Terman and Búzás, 2021). For example, while women's and children's rights are broadly endorsed, norms related to sexuality and migration tend to be championed by only a subset of states.

These findings suggest that shaming frequency in a given issue area may be correlated across dyads when they share the same sender. Recent research further shows that, due to the UPR's institutional design and the role of NGOs, states are more likely to shame countries that other states are shaming (Kim, 2023). When analyzing such shaming data using an OLS regression model with fixed effects for sender, target, and year, these valuable information— sender heterogeneity, target heterogeneity, and network effects—is lost in the analysis.

To address this while providing robust evidence for Hypothesis 1, I estimate the marginal effect of political affinity using additive and multiplicative random effects model (Hoff, 2015,

2021). Specifically, I construct seven matrices of shaming counts with each row and column as reviewer and target countries. These seven clusters of issue areas follow that of Terman and Byun's (2022). I then estimate regression coefficients $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ in the following model using Markov chain Monte Carlo (MCMC) algorithm that provides Bayesian inference for the parameter:[3]

$$
\begin{gathered}
y_{i,j} = \boldsymbol{\beta}^T \boldsymbol{X}_{i,j} + \boldsymbol{u}_i^T \boldsymbol{v}_j + a_i + b_j + \epsilon_{i,j}, \\
\text{where } \boldsymbol{u}, \boldsymbol{v} \sim \text{i.i.d. } N_{2r}(\mathbf{0}, \Psi) \\
\boldsymbol{a}, \boldsymbol{b} \sim \text{i.i.d. } N_2(\mathbf{0}, \Sigma) \\
\{(\epsilon_{i,j}, \epsilon_{j,i}) : i < j\} \sim \text{i.i.d. } N_2(\mathbf{0}, \sigma^2 \begin{pmatrix} 1 & \rho \\ \rho & 1 \end{pmatrix})
\end{gathered}
\tag{4.1}
$$

In equation 4.1, $y_{i,j}$ is the number of shaming from reviewer i to target j in a given issue area, where $\boldsymbol{X_{i,j}}$ is a matrix of covariates including political affinity and other control variables included in the original analysis. a_i, b_j represent reviewer- and target-effects on the number of shaming in a given dyad. ρ is a scalar parameter between -1 and 1 and captures reciprocity of the dyad, while $\boldsymbol{u}_i^T \boldsymbol{v}_j$ represents third-order network effects. Our interest is the estimates and p-value of the regression coefficient for the variable political affinity.

Table 4.1 reports these regression coefficients for each AME model with a subset of shaming data by issue area. The results are again in favor of the view that states are more likely to shame adversaries than allies, regardless of the issue area. All estimates have a very small margin of error. The p-value is the probability that a standard normal random variable exceeds the corresponding z-stat in absolute value, where z-stat is obtained by dividing the posterior means by their posterior standard deviations.

[3]Gibbs sampling is used. The estimation process essentially iteratively simulates the values of the parameters and hyperparameters given the multivariate conditional distribution, thereby generating a Markov chain having a stationary distribution equal to the target posterior distribution. Simulated values from this chain can be used to approximate the posterior quantities of interest (Hoff, 2021).

Table 4.1: Effects of Geopolitical Affinity on Shaming Counts, by Theme

	Model(s)	Estimate	p-value
1	Civil-Political Rights	-0.044^{***}	0.000
2	Governance and Public Service	-0.083^{***}	0.000
3	Migration	-0.264^{***}	0.000
4	Physical Integrity Rights	-0.311^{***}	0.000
5	Race and Religious Discrimination	-0.808^{***}	0.000
6	Socio-Economic Rights	-0.327^{***}	0.000
7	Women, Children, LGBTQ, Disabled	-0.078^{***}	0.000

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Note: The p-value is the probability that a standard normal random variable exceeds the corresponding z-stat in absolute value, where z-stat is obtained by dividing the posterior means by their posterior standard deviations.

4.4.2 Hypothesis 2

Above, I presented evidence that states are more likely to shame adversaries than allies across all issue areas. The next step is to examine whether, controlling for affinity, states vary in the issue areas they prioritize when engaging in shaming.

Methods Prior research has described the relationship between political costs and normative commitments in shaming as "difficult to disentangle" (McCarty, 2011, 43; Terman and Búzás, 2021, 4). To address this challenge of isolating issue emphasis from other predictors, I use standardized residuals from the models in Equation 4.1, estimated separately for each issue area. These residuals indicate whether a state's shaming behavior exceeds or falls short of what would be expected given the global popularity of that issue, the political costs of the shamer, human rights conditions in the target country, and how vocal and popular the shamer and the target country are in general with respect to the issue. Importantly, I do not compare the absolute magnitudes of residuals across models. Instead, I treat residuals within each issue area as signals of systematic deviation from what is expected from the model: for example, if State A persistently underreacts to Issue X while State B consistently overreacts, these patterns identify distinctive issue emphases. This approach enables me to

capture normative variation while holding constant the structural determinants of shaming behavior.

In addition to the seven standard clusters, I treat LGBT rights as a distinct subcategory, originally nested under the vulnerable populations cluster.[4] Given the rising salience and contestation of LGBT rights in global discourse, this sub-issue merits separate analytical attention (Alter et al., 2019, 457; Park et al., 2020; Toosi, 2025). Within the UPR process, states diverge sharply on whether to raise LGBT rights in shaming. Of the 195 countries that engage in shaming during any UPR cycle, 150 never mention the lack of LGBT protections in other countries. Yet, eight states have issued over 200 LGBT-related statements, and seven more have issued over 150, resulting in an average of 88.15 LGBT-related shaming statements (SD = 99.40). The weak correlation between scaled mean residuals for the vulnerable populations cluster and LGBT rights (Pearson's $r = 0.26$) further justifies treating LGBT rights as a separate dimension in the community detection analysis.[5]

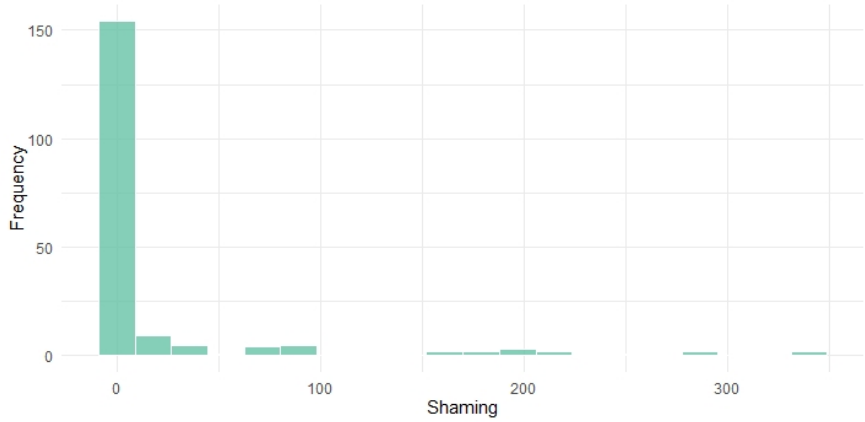


Figure 4.3: Distribution of Shaming Count on LGBT Issue across Countries

Note: Top defenders of LGBT rights at the UPR are Canada, Netherlands, France, Spain, Argentina, Norway, Chile, Czech Republic (> 200), Slovenia, Uruguay, USA, Australia, United Kingdom, Brazil, and Sweden (> 150).

Figure 4.4 presents a weighted bipartite graph where one set of nodes represents coun-

[4]While recognizing disagreement, e.g. Mertus, 2007.

[5]The UPR data source, UPR Info, applies multi-label classification, assigning multiple issue labels to each statement based on its content.

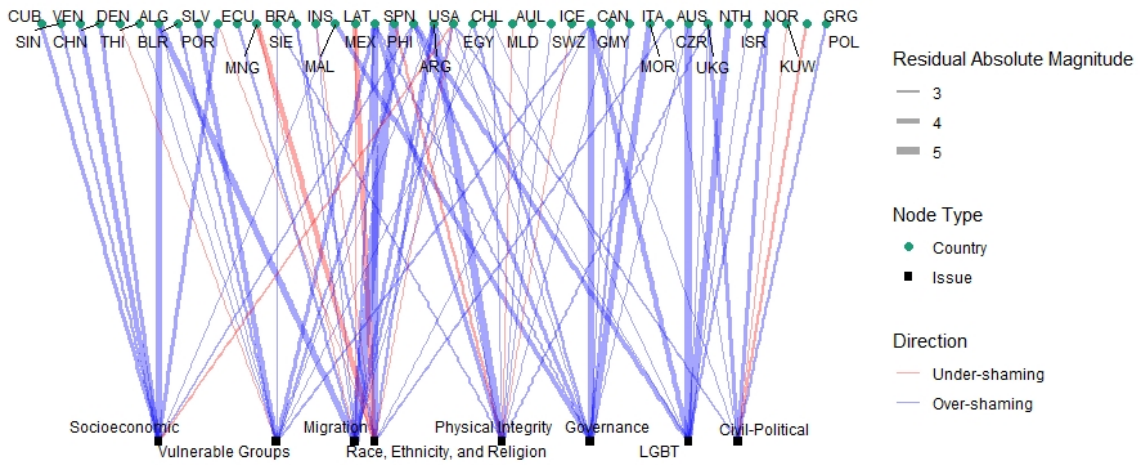


Figure 4.4: Raw Average Residual Shaming per Country–Issue

Note: Edges represent the standardized average residuals of shaming for each country–issue pair. Blue lines denote over-shaming relative to model expectations, red lines denote under-shaming. Edge thickness reflects the absolute magnitude of the residual. To simplify visualization, only edges with an absolute value greater than 2 are shown.

tries and the other set represents issue areas. Edges connect countries to the issues they disproportionately emphasize or de-emphasize, with edge weights corresponding to the standardized average residuals shaming per sender-issue, across all targets it had ever shamed in the issue domain. That is, each edge in the network represents the extent to which a country disproportionately emphasizes (blue line) or de-emphasizes (red line) a given issue area in their shaming, after accounting for factors that were included as covariates in the previous network model. Thicker line means a high absolute value of the average of the standardized residual. The visualization only depicts a part of the matrix created, as it is set to include edge absolute weights higher than 2 for simplicity in visualization that focuses on meaningful

variation.[6]

The next empirical step in detecting heterogeneity in countries' shaming profiles is to represent each country as an eight-dimensional vector summarizing its relative emphasis across issue areas. Table 4.2 illustrates this approach by displaying the standardized residuals for the United States alongside those of the countries most similar and most dissimilar to its shaming profile.

Issue Area	**United States**	**Switzerland**	**China**
Civil-Political Rights	2.82	1.66	-0.91
Socioeconomic Rights	-2.91	-0.26	3.27
Governance and Public Services	2.23	0.90	-0.67
LGBT Rights	1.27	0.14	-0.37
Migration	2.94	0.13	-0.58
Physical Integrity Rights	1.11	2.10	-1.11
Racial, Ethnic, and Religious Minorities	-2.04	-0.03	-0.18
Vulnerable Groups	-1.01	-0.64	-0.45

Table 4.2: Standardized issue emphasis profiles for selected countries

Note: Switzerland is closest to the United States in terms of Euclidean distance and second closest by cosine similarity in the 8-dimensional issue preference space. China ranks as the fifth most distant from the United States in Euclidean terms and third most distant by cosine similarity.

Results Finally, to assess the degree of similarity or dissimilarity across the 193 countries, I compute distances in the 193×8 issue-emphasis matrix. While in later analysis, I measure similarity between countries with cosine similarity, for ease of interpretation, I use Pearson's correlation distance to represent the heterogeneity in issue preferences. Correlation distance is computed $1 - Cor_{ij}$. As shown in Figure 4.5, values near 0 indicate that two countries' emphasis and de-emphasis patterns across the eight issues move together, values near 1 indicate no correlation, and values approaching 2 reflect perfectly opposite profiles. The

[6]Issue emphasis is interpreted as prioritizing provision of the particular rights, and de-emphasis is interpreted as de-prioritizing and disregarding the provision of the particular rights. An exception to that interpretation is a shaming made in May 2008 in UPR Session 2 during Cycle 1, to Tonga by Bangladesh. Their recommendation is made to undermine LGBT rights: "Continue to criminalize consensual same sex, which is outside the purview of universally accepted human rights norms, according to Tonga's national legislation."

distribution shows substantial dispersion, supporting Hypothesis 2: even after accounting for affinity, states display heterogeneous preferences over which issue areas they emphasize in shaming.

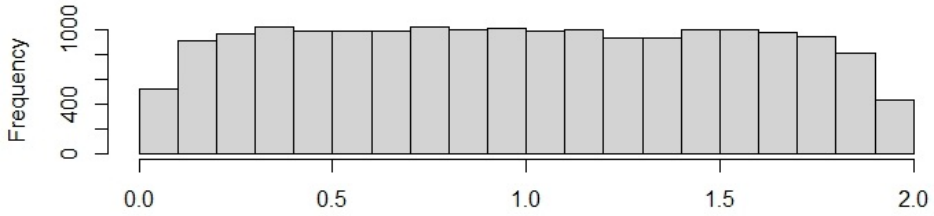


Figure 4.5: Pearson's Correlation Distance Distribution

Note: Correlation distance closer to 0 means the two countries are perfectly correlated, while 1 means no correlation and 2 means perfect negative correlation.

4.4.3 Hypothesis 3

Community Detection If states' shaming preferences diverge, do they nevertheless form meaningful communities based on those preferences? The UPR is designed as an interactive process, where working group sessions, the involvement of regional groups, and the participation of civil society actors provide opportunities for socialization (Kim, 2023). To capture this dynamic, I use the 193 $\times$ 8 matrix of issue emphasis, net of political alignment, to describe the normative communities that emerge in the UPR process.

I begin by computing cosine similarity between all pairs of countries. Cosine similarity captures the extent to which two issue profiles point in the same direction in the eight-dimensional space. Unlike correlation, it considers only the angle between vectors, not their centering. In other words, this metric reflects the relative pattern of emphasis and de-emphasis across issues, independent of overall levels of shaming.

The resulting similarity scores are projected onto a one-mode network in which edges connect pairs of countries. As shown in Figure 4.6, two countries are linked more strongly the more similar their issue profiles are. To identify groups of countries that emphasize

similar types of issues in their shaming behavior, I apply the Louvain community detection algorithm (Newman, 2004; Blondel et al., 2008). Community assignment is stable. Table 4.3 provides a snapshot characterization of these communities, and Table F.3 reports their full issue-preference profiles.

Modularity-based, unsupervised method such as Louvain is an appropriate choice, because I don't have to prespecify the number of communities or the distance metrics arbitrarily. Also, my interest is not in the absolute magnitude but in the relational structure that optimizes for within-group cohesion and between-group separation. Validation of the community detection is provided in the following subsection.

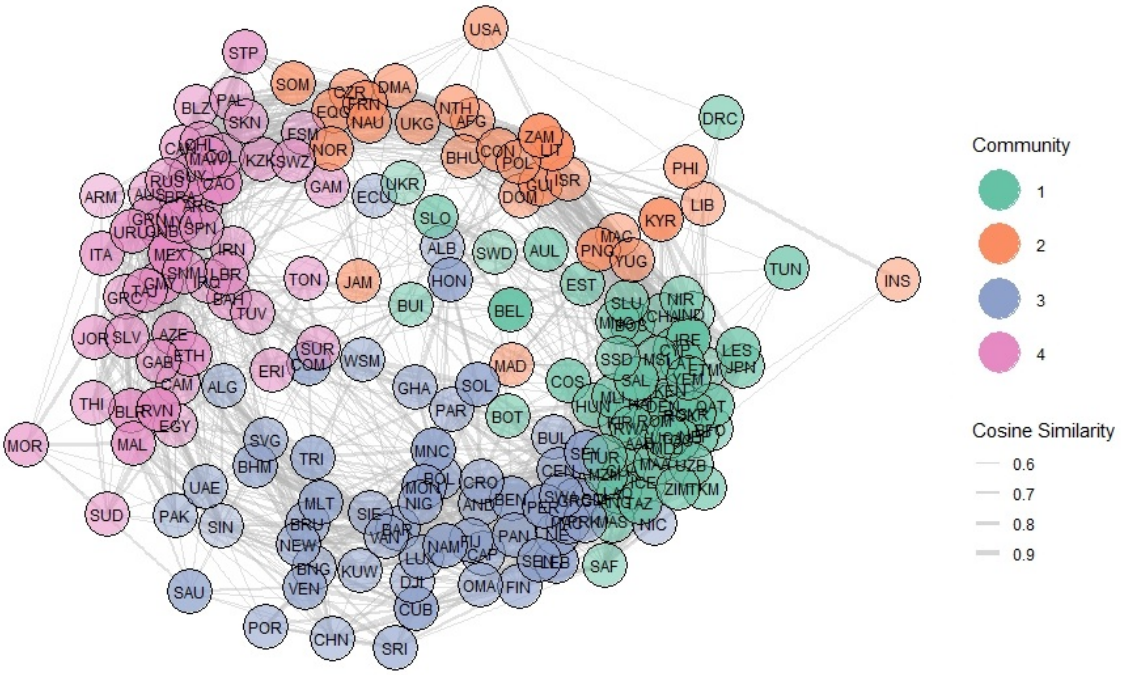


Figure 4.6: Communities by Similar Human Rights Issue Salience Profile

Note: I will change this image according to the result of Signed modularity methods. Gradation reflects Adjusted Rand Index (ARI) scores reflecting each country's structural importance for a stable community.

Considering Table 4.3 and F.3, *Systematic Undershamers* undershame in all issues. Attitudes about the civil and political rights, LGBT rights, socioeconomic rights, and racial,

ethnic, and religious minorities are a key distinction between the *Liberal Rights Advocates* and the *Only Ecosoc Bloc*. The *Governance-Driven Overshamers* overshame all issues than other communities. However, the key differentiation between this group and the *Liberal Rights Advocates* is that *Governance-Driven Overshamers* shames much less in civil and political rights and LGBT rights, while shaming much more in socioeconomic rights, governance and public services, and vulnerable populations in general. The most prototypical countries of each community is shown in Table 4.4. The full list of countries in each community is shown in Table F.4.

	Top Issues (Standardized Residuals)	**Summary**
1	`vuln` (–0.78), `ecosoc` (–0.70), `rer` (–0.69), `mig` (-0.65)	Systematic Undershamers
2	`lgbt` (+1.19), `cpr` (+1.15), `ecosoc` (-0.47), `mig` (+0.13)	Liberal Rights Advocates
3	`cpr` (-0.61), `ecosoc` (+0.54), `lgbt` (-0.52), `physint` (-0.45)	Only Ecosoc And Race Bloc
4	`vuln` (+1.02), `gps` (+0.97), `physint` (+0.82), `rer` (+0.54)	Governance-Driven Overshamers

Table 4.3: Characterization of detected communities based on top average standardized issue emphasis

Note: This table and the text above will revised.

Community	**Countries (Cosine Similarity)**
1	Cyprus (0.945), Kenya (0.944), Romania (0.940)
2	Zambia (0.946), Guinea (0.903), Nauru (0.902)
3	Luxembourg (0.895), Brunei (0.892), Vanuatu (0.856)
4	Grenada (0.957), Russia (0.938), Mexico (0.902)

Table 4.4: Prototypical Countries

Note: The countries were selected based on their cosine similarity with the centroid of each community. This table will be modified.

The composition of the detected communities aligns with existing scholarly descriptions of states' normative agendas within the international human rights network. For instance, China under Xi Jinping has famously sought to redefine the global human rights discourse by prioritizing state-led development and stability over individual civil and political rights. As the Chinese Communist Party's official ideological journal goes: "without the right to peace

and the right to development, other human rights cannot even be brought up" (Mitchell, 2021, 618–619), China's pattern in the one-mode network is to overshame socioeconomic rights. Pauselli et al. (2023) argues that China's approach to human rights is also relativism, "which holds that the interpretation of human rights should be based on the specific circumstances of each country," implying the natural coalition forming between the *Only Ecosoc And Race Bloc* and *Governance-Driven Overshamers*, each led by China and Russia. In fact, these detected community memberships closely follow the ironic voting pattern at the UNHRC. All states that rejected A/HRC/51/L.6 on Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region voted (74% of them coming from the *Only Ecosoc And Race Bloc* and *Governance-Driven Overshamers*) voted yes for A/HRC/51/L.28, a "global call for concrete action against racism," that was rejected by *Liberal Rights Advocates* and *Systematic Undershamers* (88%). Russia's influence in the detected community also reflects its efforts to advance a vision of human rights rooted in state sovereignty and social hierarchy, captured in a remark from a senior Russian foreign policy figure: "illiberal strongman democracy prevail[s] in the rising states of the non-West" (quoted in Bettiza and Lewis, 2020, 570).

The distribution of Equal Rights Coalition (ERC) membership further illustrates normative clustering. The ERC, an intergovernmental alliance of 45 member states committed to advancing LGBT rights, includes 32% of states in Community 2 and 30% of Community 4. By contrast, Community 1 and Community 3 show notably lower participation rates at 20% and 17%, respectively. This uneven distribution underscores the normative divergence between communities on issues of identity-based rights.

Together, the discovery of communities inside the human rights regime help us map why some issues receive more attention while some do not. While descriptive, it contributes to the literature by highlighting the starting point for an investigation on how socialization of different definitions of human rights happen (). The alignment between some bloc's shaming behavior and their domestic human rights policy that undermines the political rights and rights of minorities raises concerns informed by the literature that states reinforce universal

norms to combat future threats to domestic governance (Moravcsik, 2000).

Validation The modularity of a network is a scalar value that measures the strength of division of a network into communities (Clauset et al., 2004).[7] It compares the actual density of edges within communities to the expected density of such edges if edges were placed at random, while preserving the degree distribution. Modularity of the country–country similarity network in Figure 4.6 is 0.456, which indicates a strong community structure, well above the conventional threshold of 0.3 for meaningful clustering. This suggests that countries are not randomly distributed in their issue preferences. The strength of this modularity provides evidence that international shaming behavior reflects deeper normative alignments in promoting certain rights over others, even after controlling for other covariates. I will also add text about the consensus in group membership assignment across

4.4.4 Discussion

Issues and their relationships

To identify which issues most strongly differentiate the detected communities on average, I compute the variance of standardized shaming emphasis across communities for each issue area. This approach follows ANOVA logic: If a particular issue shows high between-group variance in standardized residuals, it is more likely to be divisive, i.e., emphasized by some communities and downplayed by others. This method provides a simple, interpretable ranking of issue areas by their contribution to community separation and highlights the dimensions along which normative preferences are most sharply contested. Table 4.5's first column reports this.

To complement the variance-based approach, I train a random forest classifier to predict

[7]Modularity $Q = \frac{1}{2m}\sum_{i,j}(A_{ij} - \gamma\frac{k_i k_j}{2m})\mathcal{I}(c_i, c_j)$ where A_{ij} is the adjacency matrix, k_i is the degree node of $i, k_i = \sum_j A_{ij}$, m is the total number of edges in the network, c_i is the community membership of node i, $\mathcal{I}(c_i, c_j)$ is an indicator whether i, j are in the same community. The original definition of modularity is retrieved when setting the resolution parameter $\gamma = 1$.

each country's community membership based on its standardized issue profile (Breiman, 2001; Breiman et al., 2018). To assess which issue areas are most influential in distinguishing communities, I use the model's built-in measure of feature importance: the mean decrease in classification accuracy. This is computed by permuting each issue variable in the out-of-bag (OOB) samples and observing the increase in prediction error. If shuffling an issue leads to a significant drop in accuracy, it indicates that the variable plays a key role in the model's ability to differentiate normative communities. This model-based analysis captures interactions and nonlinearities in the data, offering a robust complement to the variance-based ranking of divisive issues. This is displayed in Table 4.5's second column. The results in Table 4.5 consistently shows that civil and political rights, socioeconomic rights, protection of vulnerable populations and LGBT rights are among the top issues that differentiate between the four human rights norms communities identified above.

Issue	**Between-Group Variance**	**Mean Decrease Accuracy**
Civil-Political Rights	0.604	25.201
LGBT Rights	0.568	24.314
Protection of Vulnerable Populations	0.555	27.773
Governance and Public Services	0.454	22.654
Socioeconomic Rights	0.389	30.959
Racial, Ethnic, and Religious Minorities	0.328	24.503
Physical Integrity Rights	0.312	26.205
Migration	0.214	15.548

Table 4.5: Between-group variance and variable importance by human rights issue

Note: Between-group variance reflects how much standardized shaming emphasis varies across detected communities, following ANOVA logic. Mean decrease in accuracy comes from a random forest classifier predicting community membership; it captures the loss in predictive performance when an issue is permuted, with higher values indicating greater importance for distinguishing community assignment.

To further examine the relationships among issue areas, Figure 4.7 presents a heatmap of correlation coefficients based on the standardized residuals for each issue pair. The resulting pattern reflects broader dynamics in the contestation of human rights norms. Issue areas traditionally emphasized in liberal and procedural democratic frameworks, such as civil and political rights and physical integrity rights, have the weakest correlations with socioeconomic rights. This divergence is consistent with documented cases of norm contes-

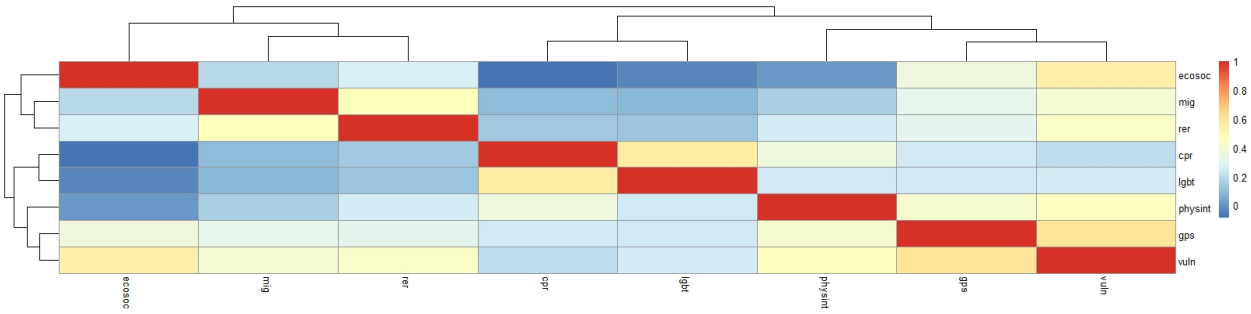


Figure 4.7: Association between shaming in each issue, net political costs

tation. For instance, China has advanced a rights hierarchy that privileges socioeconomic development and state-led stability over mechanisms of individual accountability and procedural democracy Mitchell (2021). Similarly, migration, which characterizes shaming focus of Community 4 has very low correlation with LGBT rights. Russia has promoted a normative vision centered on social cohesion and traditional moral values, often expressed as the defense of family structures. This framing has raised persistent concerns within the international human rights community, particularly with regard to the marginalization and suppression of LGBT individuals.

Influential Countries

To further assess the robustness of the network structure while also finding interesting patterns like the influence of individual countries, I performed a jackknife resampling procedure in which each country was iteratively removed and the resulting community assignment compared to the original using the Adjusted Rand Index (ARI). Lower ARI values indicate that a country's removal disrupts the topology of the network, causing reconfigurations in cluster boundaries, implying greater structural influence. For example, Latvia produced the largest drop in clustering consistency (ARI = 0.435), suggesting that it plays a central role in anchoring a community of states with similar shaming profiles. In contrast, the United States ranks 85th out of 193 in influence. Figure 4.8 presents the distribution of ARI scores across countries and Table 4.6 presents top 10 structurally important countries.

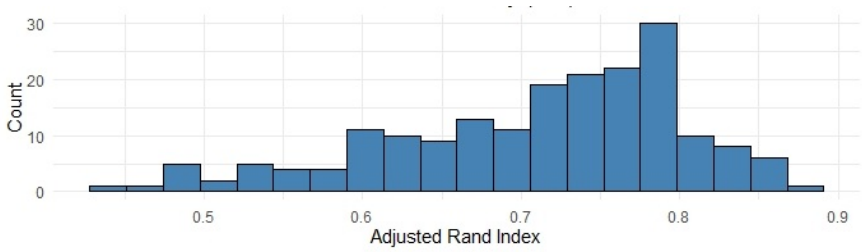


Figure 4.8: Jackknife Stability (ARI)

Note: The ARI values are left-skewed and around 0.75, meaning the community assignment is relatively stable.

Rank	Country	Jackknife ARI Score	Community
1	Latvia (LAT)	0.435	1
2	Ireland (IRE)	0.456	1
3	Lithuania (LIT)	0.474	2
4	Mexico (MEX)	0.477	4
5	Belgium (BEL)	0.491	1
6	Cameroon (CAO)	0.493	4
7	Guinea-Bissau (GNB)	0.493	4
8	South Korea (ROK)	0.505	1
9	Mongolia (MON)	0.517	3
10	Zambia (ZAM)	0.523	4

Table 4.6: Countries with Highest Structure Influence

Note: Lower ARI scores indicate countries whose removal has the greatest effect on the community structure, that its removal shifts other countries' community assignments.

While countries such as Mexico may be expected to exert structural influence due to their geopolitical visibility, others—such as Latvia, Lithuania, and Zambia—emerge as unexpectedly central. Their influence stems not from diplomatic reach, but from the consistency and distinctiveness of their shaming practices, which lend normative stability to their respective communities. These states exhibit highly consistent issue preferences that reinforce internal cohesion. This pattern aligns with findings in the foreign aid literature: minor powers, with limited influence in global politics, often emphasize human rights in their foreign policy as a principled stance (Dietrich and Murdie, 2017). In contrast, major donor governments, which are more entangled in strategic interests, tend to be guided by "realpolitik" considerations that can override human rights concerns (Dietrich and Murdie, 2017).

These findings highlight the need to look beyond traditional power politics to understand how international norms are shaped, challenged, and embedded in global institutions.

4.5 Conclusion

This paper offers three main contributions. First, it highlights the importance of norms in shaping the politicization of international shaming networks. It is the first empirical study to document heterogeneity in states' issue-specific shaming preferences while controlling for political costs. This finding carries implications for the effectiveness of the international human rights regime, as persuasion and socialization are more likely to occur when states recognize the prescriptive authority of human rights norms Clark (2013); Kinzelbach (2013). In particular, shaming that targets an issue a state genuinely values is likely to exert greater normative and political pressure.

Second, the paper contributes to the scholarly debate on when states shame their friends and why. Through a series of empirical and theoretical contributions, I demonstrate that the existing framework, while analytically elegant, oversimplifies the strategic and normative heterogeneity that characterizes states' shaming behavior at the United Nations. By replicating the original study and correcting key methodological choices, I find no robust support for the claim that states systematically shame adversaries on regime-threatening issues and allies on safer issues. Instead, both the corrected OLS estimates and the random effects based network models reaffirm a more traditional expectation: that states are broadly more lenient toward allies, regardless of the issue area.

Lastly, the paper finds new patterns of issue communities that had not been described, addressing empirical issue of unraveling the intertwined relationship between political cost and norms, that the previous literature had described as "difficult to disentangle" (McCarty, 2011, 43; Terman and Búzás, 2021, 4). The core insight is two-fold. First, targets' sensitivity to shaming is not only a function of issue but the interaction between the issue

and the relationship with the sender. This is supported by results in Figure 4.1. Second, shaming senders do have a normative agenda and preference even after controlling for political costs, supported by the community detection exercise. The resulting country–country graph reveals a structure of issue prioritization that is consistent with the existing literature. Strategically mid- to small-sized countries such as Ireland, Lithuania, Mexico, and Zambia play unexpectedly central roles in stabilizing the internal cohesion of normative blocs. Their influence does not stem from diplomatic weight, but from the consistency and distinctiveness of their shaming behavior. These findings underscore the importance of looking beyond power politics to understand how international norms are articulated.

In sum, this paper offers both a methodological correction and a conceptual reorientation. Rather than assuming uniform sensitivity to shaming across dyads or issue areas, scholars should account for the multidimensional nature of normative alignment and strategic interaction. Future research can build on these findings by exploring how norm-aligned communities evolve over time, how outlier states challenge dominant norms, and how institutional mechanisms like the UPR mediate these dynamics.

Appendix F

Network Analysis

F.1 Thematic Issue Clusters

Thematic Category	**Issues**
Civil-Political Rights	Civil Political Rights; Civil Society; Elections; Freedom of Association and Peaceful Assembly; Freedom of Opinion and Expression; Freedom of the Press; Human Rights Defenders
Governance and Public Services	Corruption; Public Security; Human Rights Education and Training; Counter-terrorism
Migration and Migrant Labor	Asylum Seekers and Refugees; Freedom of Movement; Labor; Migrants; Internally Displaced Persons
Physical Integrity Rights	Justice; Death Penalty; Detention; Enforced Disappearances; Extrajudicial Executions; Human Rights Violations by State Agents; Impunity; Torture and Other CID Treatment
Racial, Ethnic and Religious Minorities	Freedom of Religion and Belief; Minorities; Racial Discrimination; Indigenous Peoples

Socio-Economic Rights	Environment; Right to Land; Right to Water; Economic, Social and Cultural Rights; Development; Poverty; Right to Education; Right to Food; Right to Health; Right to Housing
Protection of Vulnerable Populations	Disabilities; HIV / AIDS; Sexual Orientation and Gender Identity; Rights of the Child; Trafficking; Women's Rights

Table F.1: Thematic categories and corresponding human rights issues.

This table is taken from Terman and Byun (2022), Appendix page 4.

F.2 Regression Tables

Table F.2: Effects of Geopolitical Affinity on Issue Shaming Counts (Regression for Table 4.1)

Term	Estimate	Std. Error	Statistic	p-value
(Intercept)	0.679***	0.175	3.881	0.000
Political Affinity	0.012	0.017	0.716	0.474
Civil-Political Rights	0.640***	0.024	26.401	0.000
Governance and Public Service	0.421***	0.027	15.574	0.000
Migration	0.420***	0.023	18.099	0.000
Physical Integrity Rights	0.668***	0.014	47.457	0.000
Race and Religious Discrimination	0.492***	0.025	19.947	0.000
Socio-Economic Rights	0.409***	0.022	18.755	0.000
Women, Children, LGBTQ, Disabled	0.554***	0.023	24.025	0.000
Political Affinity:Civil-Political Rights	-0.000	0.004	-0.126	0.900
Political Affinity:Governance and Public Service	0.006	0.014	0.412	0.681
Political Affinity:Migration	-0.056***	0.010	-5.503	0.000
Political Affinity:Physical Integrity Rights	-0.017**	0.008	-2.070	0.038
Political Affinity:Race and Religious Discrimination	-0.047***	0.012	-4.021	0.000
Political Affinity:Socio-Economic Rights	-0.021	0.016	-1.309	0.190
Political Affinity:Women, Children, LGBTQ, Disabled	-0.021**	0.010	-2.170	0.030
Mean Severity	0.076***	0.013	5.649	0.000
Physint Score (Sender)	-0.037	0.042	-0.878	0.380
Physint Score (Target)	-0.070	0.055	-1.280	0.200

Continued on next page

Table F.2: Effects of Geopolitical Affinity on Issue Shaming Counts (Regression for Table 4.1) (continued)

Term	Estimate	Std. Error	Statistic	p-value
Same Region	0.054**	0.017	3.187	0.001
UPR Reviewed Session	0.016	0.026	0.605	0.544
Observations: 14093				
R^2: 0.778				
Adjusted R^2: 0.771				
F-statistic : 126.2 on 379 and 13713 DF, p-value: $< 2.2e-16$				
Residual Std. Error 0.7775 (df=13713)				

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

F.3 Modularity

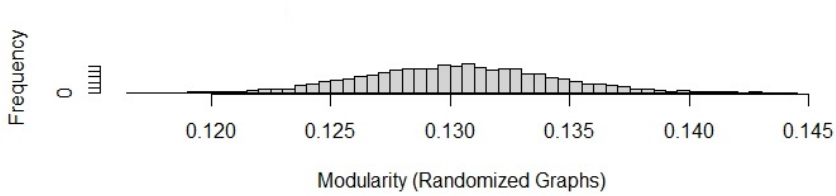


Figure F.1: Modularity from Null

Note: Modularity calculated from the community detection was 0.456.

F.4 PCA Biplot

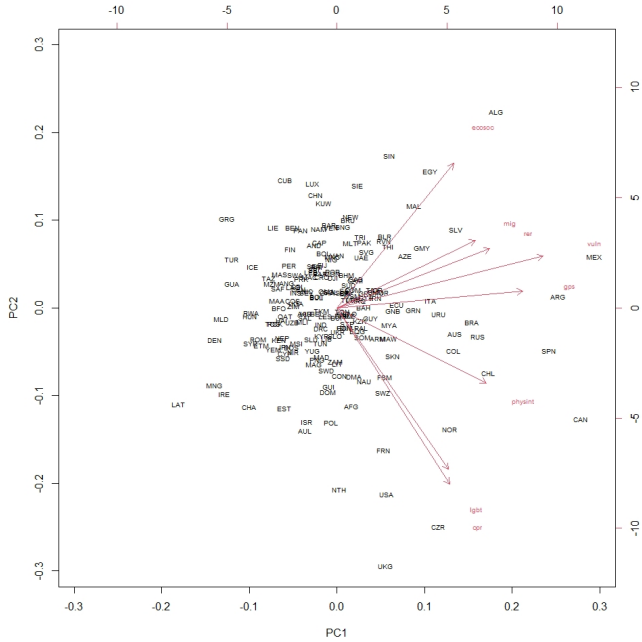


Figure F.2: Visualization of country-country, country-issue, issue-issue relationships

Note: In the PCA biplot, each country is represented as a point in the reduced-dimensional space defined by the first two principal components, while issue areas appear as directional vectors indicating their contribution to variation.

The figure visualizes principal component analysis (PCA) on the 193 by 8 matrix of each country's scaled mean residuals for each issue to visualize the structure of issue-based variation across countries in a two-dimensional space. The direction of the arrow shows where the values of that issue are increasing the most across the dataset. The angle between arrows tells you the correlation between issues, where small angle means positive correlation and 90 degrees mean uncorrelated, and opposing directions negatively correlated. Figure 4.7 heatmap depicts the relationships between issues more holistically, but algins with this Figure too.

F.5 Issue Preferences by Community

Community	Interpretive Label	cpr	ecosoc	gps	lgbt	mig	physint	rer	vuln
1	Systematic Undershamers	-0.28	-0.70	-0.59	-0.25	-0.65	-0.23	-0.69	-0.78
2	Liberal Rights Advocates	1.15	-0.47	-0.11	1.19	0.13	-0.09	-0.33	-0.16
3	Only Ecosoc and Race Bloc	-0.61	0.54	-0.24	-0.52	0.22	-0.45	0.34	-0.06
4	Governance-Driven Overshamers	0.37	0.41	0.97	0.21	0.39	0.82	0.54	1.02

Table F.3: Standardized issue-specific shaming preferences by community.

Note: Higher values indicate greater relative emphasis on a given issue, net political affinity and structural factors.

F.6 Full List of Community Membership

Community 1			
Antigua & Barbuda	Australia	Belgium	Burkina Faso
Bosnia & Herzegovina	Botswana	Burundi	Chad
Costa Rica	Cyprus	Denmark	Congo - Kinshasa
Estonia	Timor-Leste	Guatemala	Haiti
Hungary	Iceland	India	Ireland
Japan	Kenya	Kiribati	Laos
Latvia	Lesotho	Mauritania	Mauritius
Moldova	Mali	Montenegro	Marshall Islands
Mozambique	Nepal	Niger	Qatar
South Korea	Romania	Rwanda	Slovakia
St. Lucia	South Sudan	Eswatini	Sweden
Syria	Tanzania	Togo	Tunisia
Turkey	Uganda	Ukraine (0.16)	Uzbekistan
Yemen	Zimbabwe		

Community 2			
Afghanistan	Bhutan	Congo - Brazzaville	Czech Republic
Dominica	Dominican Republic	Equatorial Guinea	France
Guinea	Indonesia (0.11)	Israel	Jamaica
Kyrgyzstan	Libya	Lithuania	Maldives
Madagascar	Nauru	Norway	Netherlands
Philippines (0.19)	Papua New Guinea	Poland	Somalia
United Kingdom	United States	Serbia	Zambia

Community 3			
Albania (0.15)	Algeria	Andorra	Angola
Barbados	Benin	Bahamas	Bangladesh
Bolivia	Brunei	Bulgaria	Cape Verde
Côte d'Ivoire	Central African Republic	China	Comoros
Croatia	Cuba	Djibouti	Ecuador (0.11)
Fiji	Finland	Ghana	Georgia
Honduras (0.07)	Kuwait	Lebanon	Liechtenstein
Luxembourg	North Macedonia	Malta	Monaco
Mongolia	Namibia	New Zealand	Nicaragua
Nigeria	Oman	Pakistan	Panama
Paraguay	Peru	Portugal (0.12)	North Korea
Saudi Arabia (0.16)	Senegal	Seychelles	Sierra Leone
Singapore	Solomon Islands	Sri Lanka	St. Vincent & Grenadines
Eswatini	Trinidad & Tobago	United Arab Emirates	Vanuatu
Venezuela	Samoa		

Community 4			
Argentina	Armenia	Austria	Azerbaijan
Bahrain	Belarus	Belize	Brazil
Cambodia	Canada	Cameroon	Chile
Colombia	Egypt	Eritrea	Ethiopia
Micronesia	Gabon	Germany	Guinea-Bissau
Greece	Grenada	Guyana	Iran
Iraq	Italy	Jordan	Kazakhstan
Liberia	Malaysia	Malawi	Mexico
Morocco	Myanmar (Burma)	Palau	Russia
Republic of Vietnam	St. Kitts & Nevis	Slovenia	San Marino
Spain	Sao Tome & Principe	Sudan	Suriname
Switzerland	Tajikistan	Thailand	Tonga
Tubalu	Uruguay		

Table F.4: Countries grouped by detected community

Note: Countries that have cosine similarity with the centroid less than 0.02 have an additional note inside the parentheses. Countries with cosine similarity noted implies these countries are at the border of each community, not sharing much similarity in issue profiles with the rest of the community members, although classified into this group.

F.7 Visualiztion of Country-Country, Country-Issue, Issue-Issue in one figure

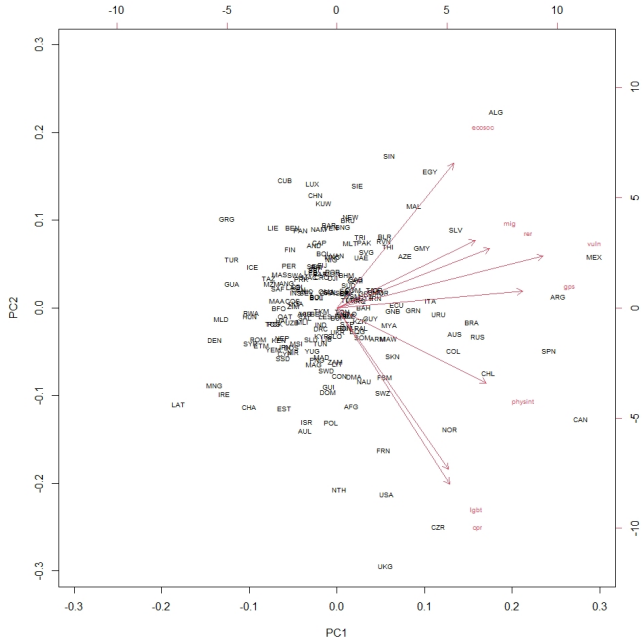


Figure F.3: PCA Results with country names